

Al Mallette

Vintage Year



The story of Joe DiMaggio's fantastic 56-game hit streak in 1941 (Page 4d) brought back memories of one of the vintage years in sports — both national and local.

It was a year of troubles in Europe — and war clouds were slowly creeping toward the United States. But the fun and frolic of sports that year seemed to put those war dangers behind closed doors — until Dec. 7, that is.

Anyway, you'd think that a guy who hit in 56 straight games, then immediately ran off on another 16-game streak would dominate the baseball batting race.

Not so. Joe D. didn't come close with his .357.

That same vintage year saw a young Boston Red Soxer named Theodore Williams (Terrible Ted to pitchers) whack the ball for a .406 average — the last major leaguer to hit .400.

That September, while Williams was chasing the coveted .400 trophy, a youngster moved up to the St. Louis Cardinals from Rochester to start his own fabulous career. Stan Musial gave a tip on things to come by batting .426 for the dozen games he played.

The Elmira papers that year also were full of the feats of a beloved ex-Elmira Pioneer, Pete Reiser.

Pistol Pete was only a year in the majors when he won the 1941 National League bat title with a .343 mark.

Pete was one of the big reasons Leo Durocher's Dodgers won the National League pennant for Brooklyn — and all Flatbush went wild because it was Brooklyn's first flag in 21 years. The joy was short-lived, however, the Yanks bombed the Brooks, 4-1, in the Series.

That also was the year of "THE Fight", that memorable, classic hit-and-run show staged by Billy Conn (all 171 pounds of him) against the greatest destroyer the heavyweight division has know, Joe Louis. The Brown Bomber, of course, staged his own ending, knocking out brash Billy in the 13th and saving his title.

Louis had a great year in '41. Besides Conn, Joe KO'd Red Burman in five, Gus Dorazio in two, Abe Simon in 13, Tony Musto in nine, Buddy Baer in seven and Lou Nova in six.

Still with boxing, 1941 saw the start of another shooting star — one that was to become the shiningest of all. Sugar Ray Robinson hit the fight scene like a tornado with a KO of Pete Lello

and exciting decision wins over Sammy Angott, Fritz Zivic and Marty Servo.

And what a year for football.

Stanford and Frankie Albert unveiled Clark Shaughnessy's dazzling T-formation and rocked powerful Stanford in the Rose Bowl, 21-13 — and Shaughnessy's T since has become THE offense in football.

Albert, of course, was one of the all-time great quarterbacks, but that also was the year that guy from Georgia was romping up and down gridirons with the first face mask of note. Frankie Sinkwich had a special helmet with a gauze-wrapped bar around the chin to hold a broken jaw in place. And he was All-American.

Pro football wasn't big news in those days — not like today, anyway. But the sport had big heroes in Sammy Baugh, Don Hutson, Cecil Isbahl, Davey O'Brien, and Sid Luckman was directing his Chicago Bears to The Monsters of the Midway tag. These are the men credited with making the pros.

On the local front, Barry's and Gerber's were tops in softball but three guys made their City League debuts that season — and they're still at it. I'm speaking, of course, about Dave Buono, Leo Makovitch and Charley Hall,

Sal Maglie, a 20-game winner; Ray Roche, a 15-game winner; Eddie Robinson, Eddie Kobesky, bat champ Frankie Madura, duck-caller Andy Cohen and his cohort Alex Monchak were the heroes of Elmira baseball — and they attracted 125,000 to Dunn Field.

That was the year, too, that EHS football boss Art Hirst turned around his quarterback and made center Red McCarthy and QB Bob Kirkendall line up butt to butt — sort of a reversed T. It didn't work too well.

The YMCA Blackhawks (Leon Ropel, Lou Pal, Junker Johnston, Bob Robinson and Co.) was the hottest semi-pro basketball team around; and that was the year, too, that Tommy Reid, Babe Fitch, Dutch Bennett, Jack Casey, Jack Biggs and Harry Furman put an end to Binghamton Central's (Bill Gabor, Bill Chanecka and Co.) long win streak.

See what memories the story on Joe D. revived? But you have to admit, 1941 was one of the great vintage years in sports.